# The Physics and Astronomy Students' Association's Constitution

Ratified October 17, 2025

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# Abbreviation and Definition Guide

Throughout this document many abbreviations will be used. This is a guide to those abbreviations.

- PASA: Physics and Astronomy Students' Association
- SU: Students' Union
- PHAS: Physics and Astronomy
- PHAS Department: Department of Physics and Astronomy
- AGM: Annual General Meeting
- UAC: Undergraduate Affairs Committee (hosted by the Department of Physics and Astronomy).
- CCR: Co-Curricular Record
- CRO: Chief Returning Officer
- "voting member of the Executive Council": only Vice Presidents or the President have official voting power on the Executive Council. Non-voting members are Year and Degree Representatives, and the Webmaster.
- "club year": May 1st to April 30th
- "nth year PHAS" is defined as taking the majority of PHAS required courses with the year n cohort for the purposes of this document.

# 1 Name

The name of this club is the Physics and Astronomy Students' Association, henceforth abbreviated to the acronym PASA. The club's bank account is registered under the Physics and Astronomy Student's Association.

# 2 Mission Statement

The purpose of PASA is to provide academic and social opportunities to all members. We are focused on enhancing the Physics and Astronomy (PHAS) undergraduate student experience.

# 3 Land Acknowledgement

> PASA, in the University of Calgary, located in the heart of Southern Alberta, both acknowledges and pays tribute to the traditional territories of the peoples of Treaty 7, which include the Blackfoot Confederacy (comprised of the Siksika, the Piikani, and the Kainai First Nations), the Tsuut'ina First Nation, and the Stoney Nakoda (including Chiniki, Bearspaw, and Goodstoney First Nations). The City of Calgary is also home to the Métis Nation of Alberta Region 3.
>
> The University of Calgary is situated on land Northwest of where the Bow River meets the Elbow River, a site traditionally known as Moh'kins'tsis to the Blackfoot, Wîchîspa to the Stoney Nakoda, and Guts'ists'i to the Tsuut'ina. On this land and in this place we strive to learn together, walk together, and grow together "in a good way."

An explanation of the 94 calls to action formed by the Truth & Reconciliation Commission can be found at Reconciliation Education, and serves as first place for learning about current issues facing indigenous populations in Canada.

# 4 Additional Acknowledgments

PASA acknowledges and will abide by the Students' Union (SU) by-laws and policies unless otherwise approved by the finance commission. We are aware that PASA will no longer remain a Student Union club if a policy or a by-law is contravened without ratification.

PASA is bound by the Students' Union Review Board, the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms, the Alberta Individual Rights Protection Act, and the laws and regulation of the United Federation of Planets.

# 5 Membership

Membership is open to everyone provided that at least 75% of the members of the club are undergraduates of the University of Calgary. Memberships may only be authorized and thus sold by the current PASA President, VP Finance, VP Events, VP Academic, VP Internal, and VP Communications.

## 5.1 Membership Costs

The cost of membership is $10 for a yearly membership, and $5 per semester. Yearly memberships are valid for the full club year in which they were bought, including the Spring and Summer semesters. Semesterly memberships are valid for either a) September to December, or b) January through August.

A Yearly membership may be changed to a Semesterly membership on request of the membership holder at any time before the start of the Winter Semester of that school year, and the monetary difference between the Yearly and one Semesterly membership will be reimbursed by the current PASA President or VP Finance.

During the month of September, students who are attending their first year at the University of Calgary are entitled to a discounted price of $5 for a yearly membership.

Memberships are free for the current Executive Council for the given year. Past Presidents who have served a full term/ for a full club year are entitled to free memberships for life.

Those who wish to be part of the PASA Discord Server but not gain access to any PASA resources (club room, events, etc.) may purchase an online membership free of charge.

# 6 Code of Conduct

Memberships are provided at the discretion of the PASA Executive Council. The Code of Conduct is an agreement between the members of PASA and PASA itself. The agreement is as follows:

1. Your membership is licensed only to the person named on your membership card and is non-transferable.
2. You are expected to maintain a respectful attitude towards other members of PASA. Repeated behaviors that make other members uncomfortable are unacceptable.
3. The PASA room is a shared space, and those in this space must share it.
    - Desks, shelves and surfaces in PASA are not to be used for the storage of personal effects for longer than during the course of a single day; only cubbies are exempt from this restriction.
    - Members are responsible for cleaning up after themselves.
    - Members are to respect PASA's room and all that is stored within it.
    - The television should be used in such a way as to ensure that as many people as possible are able to enjoy it.
    - Excessive perfumes and offensive smells should be avoided in PASA, as a courtesy to all who use the space.
4. Violence, harassment, or offensive and/or blatantly discriminatory language, actions, or communication are not permitted. The Executive Council has the final say on determining if one of the previously stated is indeed a breach of the Code of Conduct.
5. Violation of any of the above terms will result in a warning or immediate revocation of membership privileges, at the discretion of the PASA Executive Council.

The executive reserves the right to review the conduct of any member for any reason, given reasonable cause.

Memberships can be revoked by a majority vote by the voting members of the Executive Council should a member or executive be found in violation of the agreement. Standard practice is to discuss revoking memberships when a member or executive re-offends after receiving a verbal warning, but this is at the discretion of the Executive Council.

# 7 Finances

The President and VP Finance are in charge of managing the club's finances and bank account. Members are able to request a copy of the most recent Annual Financial Report, which is compiled at the end of each club year. The club year ends April 30$^{th}$ each year.

All money received from goods sold by PASA will go towards the maintenance of the PASA community unless explicitly stated in an events description or at the time of purchase.

# 8 Officials

The PASA Executive Council, also referred to as the Council of Nobles, consists of permanent/required positions and not required positions.

The following required positions are as follows:

- Sovereign High Lord/Lady (President)
- Arch-Scholar (VP Academic)
- Overseer of the Occasions (VP Events)
- Master of Coin (VP Finance)
- Keeper of the Interior (VP Internal)
- Herald of Information (VP Communications)

The following not required positions are as follows:

- Year Representative
- Degree Representative
- Webmaster

Positions are referred to freely by either name in this document. Together, they form the ruling body of the Petty Realm of PASA, a fictional and wholly self-contained status.

The required positions hold voting powers on the Executive Council, while the not required positions do not have voting powers. The PASA Executive Council consists of both required and not required positions, and will be referred to as "voting members" or "non-voting members" of the Executive Council where required.

Members of the Executive Council cannot hold more than 1 voting role at a time, but can hold multiple non-voting roles.

In the case an executive needs to drop out or remove themselves from their position, a by-election may be held. If it is filled by another executive (duo position) the role may be left vacant unless the other executive feels the need to fill the position. For the case that an executive changes institutions but is still present in Calgary, the executive team can vote to keep this position filled by such executive for the remainder of their term.

# 9 Responsibilities of Officials

## 9.1 All Required/Voting Executives

- Includes the President, VP Academic, VP Finance, VP Events, VP Communications, and VP Internal.
- Are responsible for the recruitment of PHAS students to become members of PASA and to participate in events organized by PASA, the PHAS Department, and the University of Calgary.
- If concerns or requests are brought to the attention of any executive, it is their responsibility to inform the appropriate members of the club, department, and faculty.
- Must do their best to participate in all events.
- Are responsible for attending all executive and Annual General Meetings (AGM).
- Are allowed to sell memberships.
- Hold keys to the PASA room.

## 9.2 Sovereign High Lord/Lady (President)

- Responsible for the co-writing and finalizing of the semester reviews and annual report as required by the SU.
- Organizes general and executive meetings.
- Tracks club room usage for 1 week/semester.
- Maintaining signing authority on the PASA bank account.
- Has access to the PASA safe.
- The maintenance of room items and cleanliness.
- Assist in the planning and execution in all events, both academic and social.
- Ensure all activities or proposals are in line with the SU and the PHAS Department requirements.
- Provide oversight to all club administrative activities.
- Ensure that income and expenses sheet, bank statement, members list and constitution are submitted to the SU Clubs Office for PASA re-registration, in accordance to requirements outlined in the SU Clubs Manual.
- Responsible for ensuring that minutes are taken in clear terms by someone present at the meeting
- Holds the right to ask for the return of the PASA key from anyone for any reason.
- Updates the Election Norms document if a constitution change causes a change in how elections are run.
- Position may only be held by one person.
- Must be entering at least their 3rd year of studies as a PHAS major while having spent at least 2 years as a PHAS major at the University of Calgary. This is to ensure the individual in this role has sufficient experience as a PHAS student who has made connections with a sufficient number of PHAS Department faculty during their studies.

## 9.3 Arch-Scholar (VP Academic)

- Primary contact between professors and PASA.
- Responsible for dealing with tutoring requests.
- Primary organizer of academic events such as the Research Night and LaTeX Seminar.
- Position may be held by one or two people.
- Must be entering at least their 3rd year of studies as a PHAS major while having spent at least 2 years as a PHAS major at the University of Calgary. This is to ensure the individual in this role has sufficient experience as a PHAS student who has made connections with a sufficient number of PHAS Department faculty during their studies.

## 9.4 Overseer of the Occasions (VP Events)

- Responsible for the organization and execution of all social events.
- Responsible for social event reservations for on-site and off-site activities.
- Liaison between SU Clubs Director and the SU VP of Student Life.
- Position may be held by one or two people.
- Position holder(s) must be registered as Designated Booker(s) on Clubhub in accordance to SU Policy.

## 9.5 Master of Coin (VP Finance)

- Responsible for management and accurate acquisition of club finances.
- Has access to the PASA safe.
- Holds signing authority for club bank account.
- Responsible for buying supplies, food, and beverages for the club.
- Ensure that club finances are accurately reported and kept up to date throughout the term of the position.
- Position may only be held by one person.

## 9.6 Herald of Information (VP Communications)

- Responsible for maintaining the PASA email list(s).
- Responsible for emailing all members to inform members of events or activates occurring in/with PASA, the Physics Department, or the University of Calgary.
- Responsible for external communications sent to the PASA email account.
- Updating the notification boards in PASA.
- Maintaining any applicable online social media sites or notice boards.
- Design and distribute posters for events.
- Position may only be held by one person.

## 9.7 Keeper of the Interior (VP Internal)

- Maintaining general cleanliness of the PASA club room, and has the authority to manage Code of Conduct offences to the PASA room under their discretion. Members are still expected to clean up after themselves.
- Main liaison between the general population and executive board.
- ~~Must take cans and bottles to the bottle depot for refund.~~
- Position may be held by one or two people.

## 9.8 Year Representatives

- Responsible for representing their year's cohort of students' voices to the Executive Council if said year does not have adequate representation on the Executive Council.
- Responsible for reporting events and activities directly to students in designated year.
- Must be a PHAS major that is taking their majority of classes with that year.
- Position may only be held by one person per year represented.
- This position does not have a vote on the Executive Council and is defined as a non-voting member, but does have input and is expected to attend all executive meetings.

### 9.9 Degree Representatives

- If VP Academic is a Physics major, Astrophysics majors will have the option to elect an Astrophysics Degree Representative by popular vote at the first AGM of the year following the election. Similarly, if VP Academic is an Astrophysics major, Physics students will have the option to elect a Physics Degree Representative. The Degree Representative must be a PHAS major opposite of the VP Academic. This role cannot be held by a major outside of PHAS.
- Position may only be held by one person. It is highly recommended that this representative be in their 3rd year of studies as a PHAS major or above.
- This position does not have a vote on the council. They are invited to, but not required to attend, all executive meetings. Should they choose not to attend executive meetings, they will coordinate with the President and VP Academic as appropriate.

### 9.10 Webmaster

- Responsible for the maintenance of PASA's website.
- Position may be held by one or two people.
- This position does not have a vote on the council. They are invited to, but are not required to attend, all executive meetings.

## 10 PASA Day

PASA day is the celebration of the reformation of PASA into a Petty Realm. This date is marked as February 5$^{th}$, 2020. February 5th shall henceforth be recognized as an official PASA holiday.

## 11 PASA Pet

Every month during the term of an executive team, a new pet provided by the members shall be inducted as the official PASA Pet. The Pet shall have their picture on the website, and announcement shall be made to coronate them. How The Pet is selected is to the discretion of the current executive team.

## 12 Meetings

There will be a minimum of one general meeting, also known as a meeting of the PASA Parliament (never to be referred to by its initials in an official communication), and two executive meetings per semester. Quorum for a general meeting will consist of ten members of the club excluding voting members of the Executive Council. Quorum for an executive meeting will consist of four voting members of the executive or a majority, whichever is larger. A general meeting can be called by the President of the PASA, or by 20 members. Executive meetings may be called by the President or by three voting and/or non-voting members of the Executive Council.

Traditionally, the AGM is held in September at the same time as the Cubby Brawl event, known as the September AGM, and once in the Winter semester to ratify any proposed changes necessary before the PASA Executive Council Election. It is highly recommended that this format for AGMs is followed.

## 13 Elections

There are 3 types of elections in PASA: the PASA Executive Council Election, the Representative Election, and the Webmaster Election.

## 13.1 PASA Executive Council Election

### 13.1.1 General Information

The PASA Executive Council Election is held to elect individuals into the required roles: President, VP Academic, VP Finance, VP Events, VP Communications, and VP Internal. These roles hold office for the entirety of the new club year, May 1st to April 30th.

### 13.1.2 Election Planning

PASA Executive Council Election procedures, which include the appointment of a Chief Returning Officer (CRO), will be outlined in an executive meeting held prior to February 28th of the club year. The CRO can be one or two people who are not running in the next PASA Executive Council Election. It is recommended to be a current executive who is not running for re-election. The CRO has official power to hold the PASA Executive Council Election in any way they see fit, as long as it is inline with the PASA Constitution.

PASA Executive Council Elections must be held annually, and between March 15th and April 15th of the club year.

The voting ballots must include an option to abstain for voting for any role individually. This can be the choice to leave the vote blank for a role for in-person ballots, or a direct option to abstain for online ballots. If a single individual/team runs for a position, the options must then be: Nominee, No Confidence, Abstain (or leave blank). If multiple individuals/teams run for a position, the options must then be: Nominee, Nominee, etc, Abstain (or leave blank).

### 13.1.3 Election Victory Requirements

To win the election, the candidate must win by a majority vote out of those who voted for that role. If there is a tie between two nominees when more than two nominees have run, a second vote is to be called to determine who wins the role between the top two candidates. If there is a tie between two nominees where no other nominees are in the running, the new Executive Council will vote, and the majority vote determines who will win the role.

### 13.1.4 Candidate Rules

Candidates must be enrolled in both Fall and Winter Semesters of the upcoming club year. Candidates cannot run to hold office for a single semester.

Candidates running for any executive position must disclose for the following year when asked the number of courses they will be taking, extracurricular activities/roles they may be undertaking (including clubs, sports and part time jobs), and what those extracurricular activities entail for the purpose of transparency.

Candidates who intentionally withhold this information will have their intentions announced to the membership at the debate, or where the CRO deems appropriate.

Candidates are not allowed to campaign within the doors of the PASA room, or on the PASA Discord Sever outside of a designated “campaign” channel. They are allowed to campaign outside of the room at the debates, and in private messages when asked publicly on the PASA Discord Server.

All candidates for a required Executive Council position must submit a platform, speech, or equivalent to the CRO. The CRO will display these submissions in the PASA clubroom before the voting period begins.

Candidates can only run for one voting position.

### 13.1.5 Voter Eligibility

All members of the club who have purchased memberships prior to March 1st of the club year have the right to vote and all votes carry equal weight.

#### 13.1.6 Vote by Proxy

Individuals who wish to place their vote by proxy must do so:

1. With the approval of the current executive majority.
2. At least 24 hours prior to the start of the in-person ballot casting.

#### 13.1.7 Executive Position Transfer Guidelines

It is the responsibility of the departing executive to prepare the incoming executive in their new duties before the club year ends. The departing executive must prepare official transfer documentation of these duties for the new executive to reference and to ensure a clean transition of roles. All components of transferring to a new executive, including safe and master keys, transfer documentation, and any other component necessary to allow the new executive to be complete in their role must be done by April 30th.

#### 13.1.8 No Contest

Should there be only one candidate who applies for a position, the race is declared a 'no contest'. A vote of confidence will be held at the same time as the election. If the vote of confidence is failed (less than 50% of people vote in favour of the candidate), the position will be treated as vacant (outlined below).

In the case that there are no candidates for a position, the result is declared a 'no contest' and the seat is left vacant. The executive may then either hold a by-election no later than 4 months after the position becomes vacant, or appoint an interim leader by interview to hold the position until a election is possible.

#### 13.1.9 By-Elections

By-Elections are held as required as positions on the executive become vacant. A by-election may be called by 50% of the members of the club or by the remaining members of the executive. It is strongly recommended that the by-election takes place no later than a month from when the seat became vacant.

### 13.2 Representative Election

#### 13.2.1 General Information

The Representative Election is to be held during the September AGM. Eligible roles that can be elected are: Year Representative(s), and Degree Representative. If the September AGM is unable to run, voting for Representatives will take place at the next AGM.

#### 13.2.2 Voter Eligibility

For any representative vote, all voters must hold current memberships to PASA.

For Year Representative, voters must be in that designated year, or have a majority of their classes with the designated year.

For Degree Representative, voters must be of the degree opposite to the VP Academic (Physics voters if there is an Astrophysics VP Academic, or Astrophysics voters if there is a Physics VP Academic).

#### 13.2.3 Year Representative

The Year Representative is a non-voting member of the Executive Council. Year Representatives are to provide representation for their year on the Executive Council if their year is not adequately represented on the Executive Council. It is extremely encouraged to have a First Year Representative as there are no first year students on the Executive Council. At the September AGM, the President will ask if there are any years that would like a Year Representative. The majority of that year's population must vote to want a Year Representative before a vote for the Year Representative is held. The only exception to this is for First Year Representative which will automatically go to a vote.

Voting for a Year Representative is a vote by hands for the members of that year present at the AGM. The winner must be voted in by a majority. If there is a tie between two nominees, but there is more than 2 individuals running then it goes to a vote between the two tied nominees. If there is a tie between two nominees and they are the only nominees running or left, the vote goes to a game of "Rock, Paper, Scissors". The rules of "Rock, Paper, Scissors" as to when one shoots is determined by the candidates.

Given that there is no attendance of the necessary year, a by-election may be held after the AGM and is ran by the current executive team. Normal by-election rules apply.

#### 13.2.4 Degree Representative

The Degree Representative is a non-voting member of the Executive Council. Degree Representatives are to provide representation for their specific major's population to the Executive Council, and to the PHAS Department.

Voting for a Degree Representative requires the VP Academic position to only be enrolled in one of Astrophysics or Physics, not both. A vote by the degree/major opposite that of the VP Academic must vote in majority to vote to elect a Degree Representative. If the number of students in the respective degree present at the AGM is less than approximately 25% of all members of that degree, all PHAS majors year 3 and above will be invited to cast a vote as well. The winner of Degree Representative must be voted in by a majority. If there is a tie between two nominees, but there is more than 2 individuals running then it goes to a vote between the two tied nominees. If there is a tie between two nominees and they are the only nominees running or left, the vote goes to a game of "Rock, Paper, Scissors". The rules of "Rock, Paper, Scissors" as to when one shoots is determined by the candidates.

Given that a degree representative is required but no nominees step forward, a by-election may be ran after the AGM to elect the position. Normal by-election rules apply.

### 13.3 The Webmaster Election

The role of Webmaster is to be appointed by the new Executive Council after the PASA Executive Council Election. The Webmaster must be voted in with a majority vote by the voting members of the Executive Council. Once the new Executive Council has been elected, a notice will go out to members to call for a Webmaster. After a deadline set by the notice has been passed, set by the Executive Council, the Webmaster must be voted in with a majority vote by the voting members of the Executive Council from the applicants.

### 13.4 Election Norms

PASA has in place a non-binding Election Norms document that outlines recommendations for how specific details of elections should be carried out based on the past successes and hurdles faced in previous elections, and what the member population has come to expect. If the norms change in a significant way that needs to be documented, the CRO for the election is expected to update the Election Norms document to reflect that. If the constitution changes in a way that forces a change in how elections have been run, the President is expected to update the Election Norms document to reflect the change.

### 13.5 Impeachment

Impeachment of an executive requires the unanimous vote of all other voting members of the Executive Council and/or a majority vote at a general meeting and/or a letter of non-confidence with the signatures of at least half the

total membership of the club.

Should an executive be considered for impeachment, the at-risk member must be given three days' notice prior to an executive meeting where a unanimous vote must be made with respect to their executives standing. Impeachment of an executive requires the unanimous vote of all other voting members of the executive council and/or a majority vote at a general meeting and/or a letter of non-confidence with the signatures of at least half of the membership of the club. The state of the impeached executive's membership is under discretion of the executive council.

## 14 Dissolution

PASA will dissolve if the club does not have the required number of members to remain a club as defined by the SU. Any remaining funds in the bank accounts will be donated to a charitable organization of the executive's choice, and the bank account will be closed. The department in charge of any space used by PASA will be notified, and all keys will be returned. The SU will also be notified of the dissolution. All procedures required by the SU will be followed.

## 15 Amendments

This constitution shall comprise the operating basis of PASA. The constitution of PASA may be amended by presenting an amendment in the form of a motion at an AGM. The amendment must then be passed by the majority of those present at the AGM. A copy of the amended constitution shall be submitted to the Students' Union within two weeks of ratification. Amendments to the constitution take effect once the updated constitution has been submitted to the Students' Union and made available to members.

## 16 Emergency Clause

In light of the Covid-19 Pandemic and the changes to how classes are run and access to the PASA space, this Emergency Clause has been created so that items in this Constitution can change to fit the need of the extenuating circumstance. Implementation of the Emergency Clause is done when there is a consensus by the voting members of the Executive Council or a majority vote from the general population at an AGM during times of necessary, but temporary changes.

Sections of the Constitution that can be overruled by the Emergency Clause are:

- Memberships
- Code of Conduct (alterations to the Code of Conduct cannot be made specifically to revoke the membership of those trying to pass an impeachment, with the intention of preventing said impeachment)
- Finances
- Officials
- Responsibilities of Officials
- Meetings
- Elections minus Impeachment with collaboration and consent of the CRO